



Multiple Impressions

Reimagining the in-gallery art experience through immersive audio and spatial navigation

A mobile-first gallery companion app designed to transform passive exhibition visits into immersive, self-guided journeys. From discovery to reflection, Multiple Impressions bridges the gap between visitor intention and museum experience.

UX/UI DESIGN

8 WEEKS

MOBILE APP

The Problem

The Experience Gap

Modern art galleries struggle with a subtle but critical disconnect between intention and experience.

Art is powerful — but the experience around it often isn't. Visitors arrive inspired but leave feeling unfulfilled.

- Feel overwhelmed in large exhibition spaces with unclear navigation
- Find traditional audio guides outdated, impersonal and cumbersome
- Struggle to read artwork plaques in crowded, dimly lit environments
- Lack curated pathways tailored to their available time or artistic interests

📄 **Design Challenge:** How might we design a digital companion that enhances emotional connection with art whilst reducing physical and cognitive friction inside gallery spaces?

Research Approach



User Interviews

In-depth conversations with gallery visitors to understand motivations, frustrations and unmet needs during museum experiences.



Behavioural Observation

Studying navigation patterns, decision-making moments and physical interactions within exhibition spaces.



Competitive Analysis

Comprehensive review of existing museum apps and audio guide systems to identify gaps and opportunities.

The focus extended beyond usability exploring how people emotionally and physically experience art spaces, what creates friction, and where digital intervention could genuinely enhance rather than distract.



User Personas

Persona: Shyam Sundar

Age

34

Profession

Accounts Manager

Location

Bangalore, India

Shyam enjoys exploring cultural spaces like museums, art galleries, and exhibitions when he travels or during weekends. While he appreciates art, he often finds it difficult to fully understand the meaning or background of artworks during gallery visits. He prefers guided experiences that help him connect with the stories behind the art.

Goals

- Learn the stories behind artworks and artists
- Explore museums in a structured and engaging way
- Discover new exhibitions when visiting a city
- Save interesting artworks to revisit later

Frustrations

- Limited explanations available near artworks
- Renting separate audio guide devices is inconvenient
- Difficulty navigating large museums
- Forgetting the names of artworks he liked after leaving the gallery

Competitive Analysis

Feature	Google Arts & Culture	Smartify	NGMA Audio Guide (India)
Discover Museums	✓	✓	✗
Audio Guided Tours	✗	✓	✓
Artwork Recognition / Scan	✓	✓	✗
Artwork Information & Artist Details	✓	✓	✗
Save Favourite Artworks	✗	✓	✗
In-Gallery Navigation	✗	✗	Limited
Curated Guided Tours	✗	Partial	✗
Multi-Museum Support	✓	✓	✗

Key Research Insights

Research revealed critical tensions between visitor expectations and current gallery experiences. These insights became the foundation for design decisions.

1

Autonomy with Structure

Visitors prefer exploring freely but appreciate subtle guidance. They resist rigid tours yet feel lost without pathways. The sweet spot: suggestions, not prescriptions.

2

Audio Over Reading

In crowded, dimly lit environments, audio dramatically outperforms text. Visitors want to look at art, not squint at plaques or phones.

3

Cognitive Load Challenge

Inside exhibitions, visitors are already processing spatial information, artwork details and crowds. Additional interface complexity becomes overwhelming.

4

Variable Depth of Engagement

Different users want different storytelling depths. Casual visitors prefer concise context. Enthusiasts crave deeper artistic narratives and historical connections.

5

Post-Visit Reflection

Meaningful artworks deserve revisiting. The gallery visit doesn't end at the exit door, visitors want to save, share and continue learning afterwards.

Design Principles

Research led to five clear principles that guided every design decision. These principles helped us balance a refined look with ease of use.

Art is the hero. UI stays quiet.

Interface elements recede, allowing artwork and storytelling to command attention. Restraint over decoration.

Reduce cognitive load in physical spaces.

Minimise mental effort required to navigate, understand and interact whilst inside gallery environments.

Make learning optional but accessible.

Provide depth for those who seek it, brevity for those who don't. Adapt to visitor intent.

Support both guided and self-guided exploration.

Enable structured journeys and serendipitous discovery. Flexibility without chaos.

Create a calm, premium museum-grade aesthetic.

Match the sophistication and serenity of physical gallery spaces through visual design.

The Solution

Multiple Impressions is a gallery companion that supports the entire visitor journey from initial discovery through to post-visit reflection. It extends beyond ticketing to become a cultural companion.



Discover Exhibitions

Browse current and upcoming shows with rich imagery, curator insights and visitor reviews.



Seamless Booking

Reserve timed entry tickets with minimal friction. Digital passes eliminate queues.



Indoor Navigation

Step-based spatial guidance through exhibition halls with distance cues and visual floor indicators.



Immersive Audio

Contextual storytelling that adapts to depth preference. Quick overviews or deep artistic narratives.



Save Favourites

Build personal collections of meaningful artworks. Revisit and explore further after the visit.

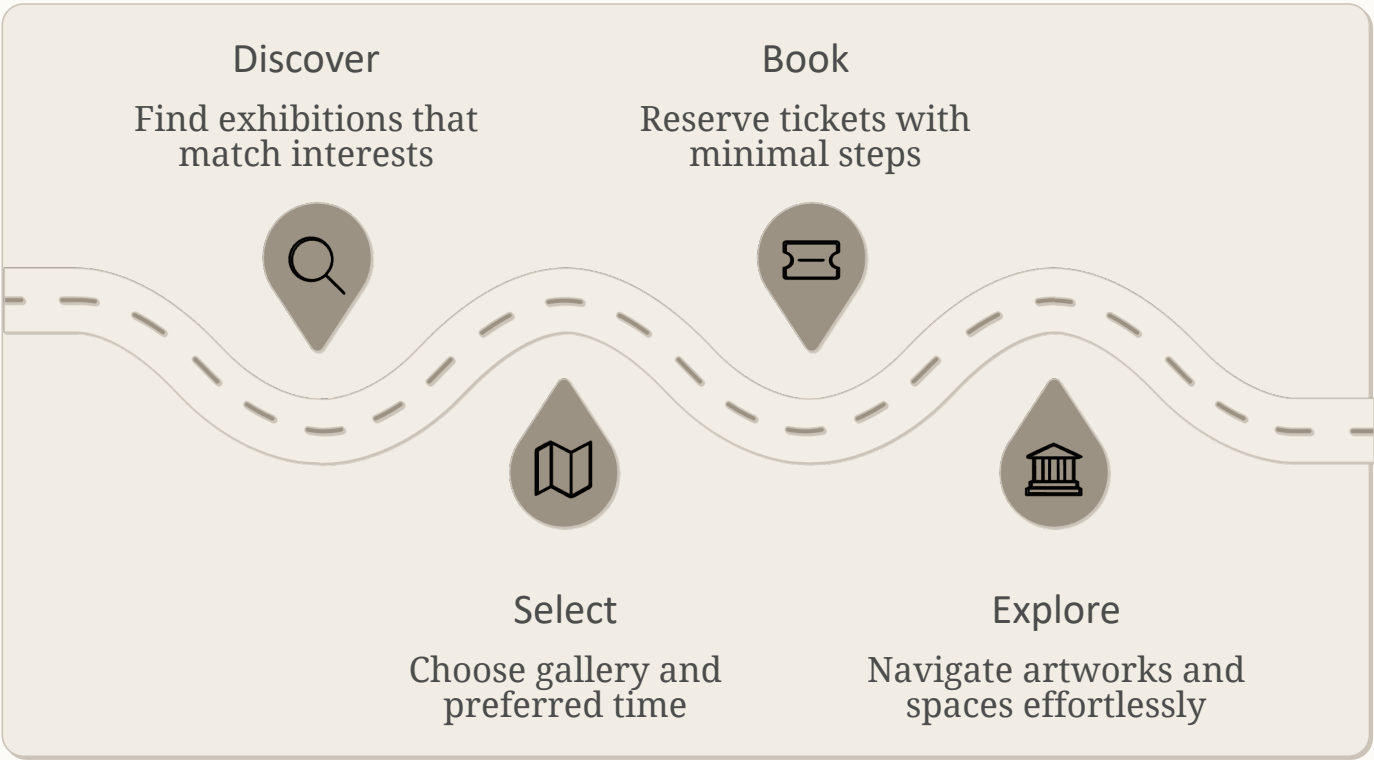


Curated Recommendations

Personalised suggestions based on viewing history, preferences and exhibition context.

Core Experience Flow

The journey is structured yet flexible, ensuring minimal friction before the visit, immersive engagement during, and continued reflection afterwards.



Each stage removes barriers whilst preserving visitor autonomy. The app becomes invisible infrastructure, present when needed, absent when not.



Immersive Indoor Navigation



The most differentiated feature is spatially guided exploration. Instead of static maps, the app provides dynamic, context-aware guidance.

This reduces confusion in large exhibition halls and allows visitors to stay present with the art rather than the interface.



Step-Based Guidance

Clear walking directions updated in real-time as visitors move through spaces.



Visual Floor Indicators

Intuitive level identification across multi-storey gallery buildings.



Distance Cues

Proximity feedback showing how far each artwork or room is from current position.



Artwork Hotspots

Featured pieces highlighted on the map with one-tap access to details.

Audio-Led Storytelling

Audio transforms passive viewing into emotional engagement. Each artwork includes layered narratives that adapt to different visitor intentions.

01

Concise Contextual Summary

Essential background - artist, period, technique - delivered in under 90 seconds for quick understanding.

02

Optional Deep-Dive Narrative

Extended storytelling exploring artistic intent, historical context and cultural significance for engaged learners.

03

Guided and Self-Guided Modes

Choose between curated tours with sequenced storytelling or freeform exploration triggered by proximity.

04

Save to Personal Collection

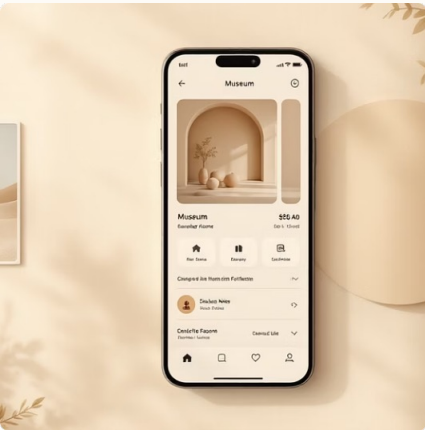
Bookmark artworks to revisit audio, read transcripts and explore related works after the gallery visit.

"The audio experience adapts to visitor intent whether they want a quick overview or a deeper artistic narrative. Learning becomes optional but irresistible."

By prioritising audio over text, the app reduces cognitive load, improves accessibility and keeps visitors' eyes on the artwork rather than their screens.

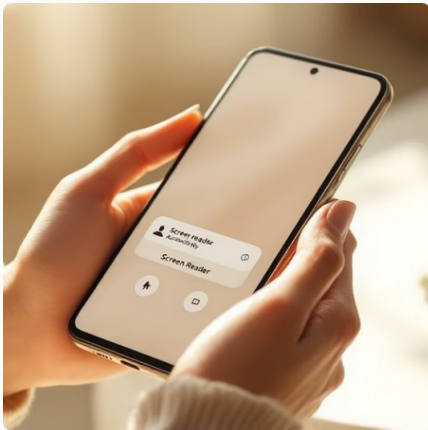
Accessibility & Inclusivity

Designing for museums requires designing for diverse age groups, abilities and cultural backgrounds. Accessibility was embedded throughout, not retrofitted.



Audio-First Learning

Reduced reliance on reading text makes content accessible to visitors with visual impairments or reading difficulties.



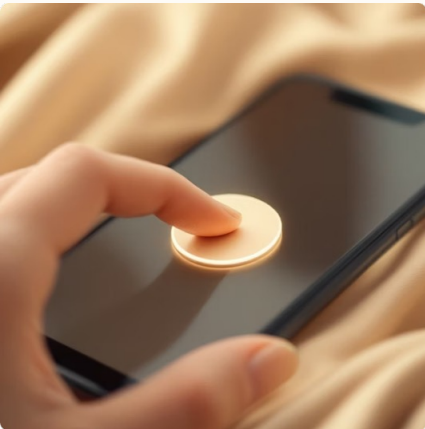
Screen Reader Support

Comprehensive semantic labelling ensures full navigation and content access for assistive technologies.



Clear Contrast Ratios

WCAG AAA-compliant colour combinations ensure legibility in various lighting conditions.



Generous Tap Targets

Minimum 44×44pt touch areas accommodate motor limitations and reduce interaction errors.



Multi-Language Capability

Interface and audio content available in multiple languages to serve international visitors.

These considerations ensure Multiple Impressions serves the widest possible audience, democratizing access to cultural experiences.

Prototype

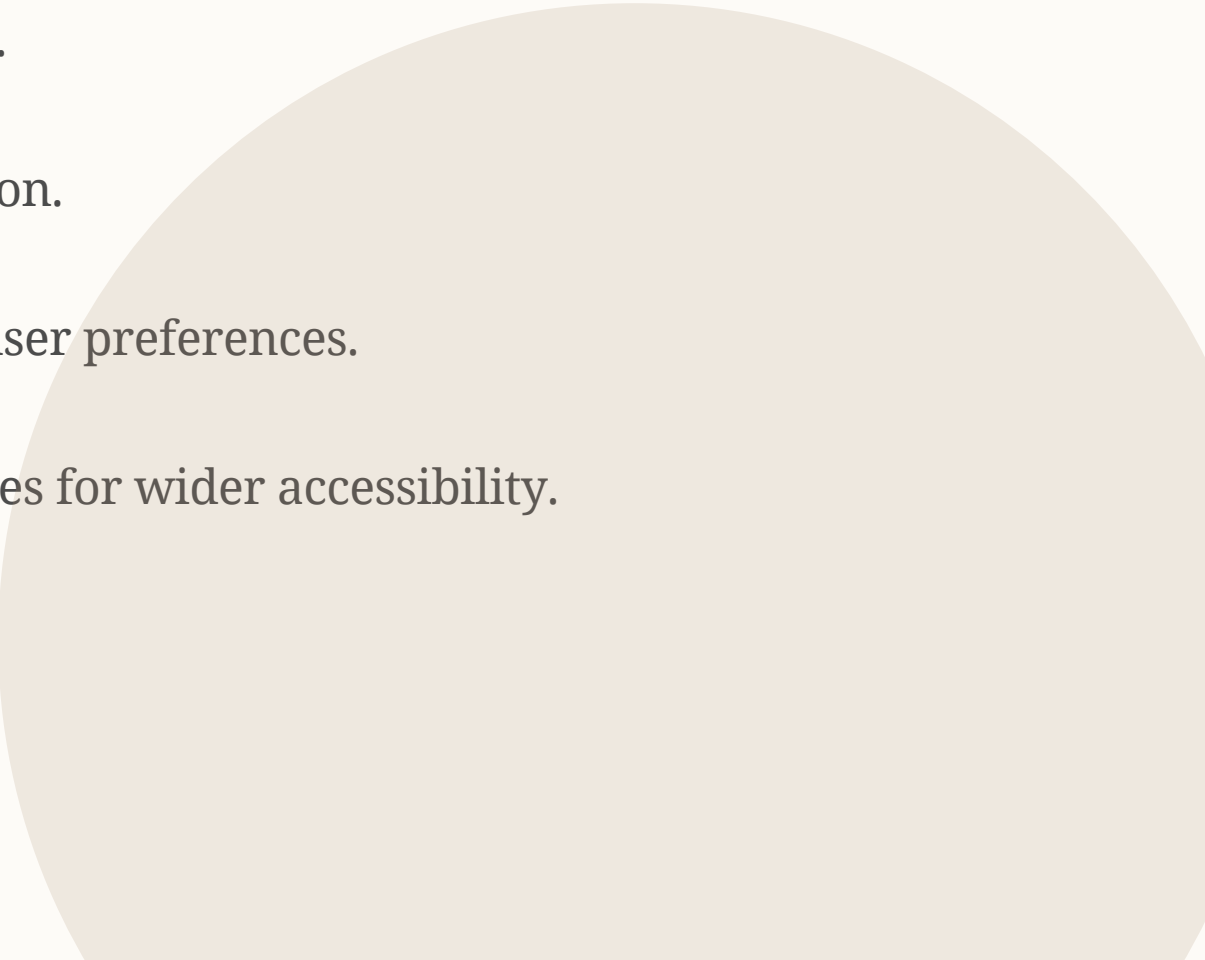
The prototype showcases the end-to-end experience of Multiple Impressions, allowing users to explore museums, discover guided tours, and interact with artwork details. It focuses on creating a smooth and intuitive journey that enhances how visitors engage with art during their gallery visit.

Multiple Impressions App Prototype



Next Steps

While the current design focuses on enhancing the in-gallery experience through guided tours and artwork exploration, there are several opportunities to further improve the product in future iterations.

- 1. User Testing with Real Visitors** - Validate the experience with real visitors to identify usability issues and improve navigation and audio interactions.
 - 2. Indoor Navigation** - Enable easy wayfinding within large museum spaces.
 - 3. Artwork Recognition** - Allow users to scan artworks for instant information.
 - 4. Personalized Recommendations** - Suggest tours and artworks based on user preferences.
 - 5. Multi-Language Audio Guides** - Provide audio guides in multiple languages for wider accessibility.
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Reflection

Designing Multiple Impressions helped me explore how digital tools can enhance cultural experiences. The project emphasized the importance of balancing technology with the physical environment of museums, ensuring that the app supports exploration without distracting from the artwork itself.